

# The Student Handbook

Everything you need to go from never having sold a piece of technology in your life, to being a digital sales professional a SaaS, AI or technology company would pay to keep.

**Learn to sell technology. Build a career in revenue.**

|                                               |                                             |                                                 |                                              |                                              |                                             |                                           |                                        |                                     |
|-----------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------|-------------------------------------|
| <b>Find</b><br>Right market,<br>right account | <b>Start</b><br>Open a real<br>conversation | <b>Qualify</b><br>Confirm a real<br>opportunity | <b>Discover</b><br>Understand the<br>problem | <b>Present</b><br>Connect<br>product to need | <b>Demonstrate</b><br>Show it in<br>context | <b>Handle</b><br>Work through<br>concerns | <b>Close</b><br>Convert to<br>customer | <b>Grow</b><br>Retain and<br>expand |
| You own this half as a Setter                 |                                             |                                                 |                                              |                                              | You own this half as a Closer               |                                           |                                        |                                     |

That line is the whole job. Every lesson in this handbook exists to help you move a real technology opportunity from one box to the next, honestly, and on purpose.

## How to use this handbook

This is not a book you read. It is a book you work. If you read all twenty-eight lessons in a weekend and do none of the drills, you will finish with the vocabulary of a technology salesperson and the ability of a spectator. Employers can tell the difference in about four minutes of an interview, and they will not hire you.

Each lesson is built the same way, and the shape is deliberate. It opens with a story, because your brain remembers situations far better than it remembers rules. Then comes the teaching, written the way a coach would explain it to you across a table, with the reasoning included so you can adapt it rather than recite it. Then a worked example, usually a transcript with coaching notes in the margin, so you can see exactly where a conversation turns. Then a case study from a real kind of technology business, with the money attached. Then a role-play brief you can run with another student. Then drills you do alone. Then the mistakes almost every beginner makes, so you can

recognise them before you make them yourself. Then what world class actually looks like. Then a self-check, so you know honestly whether the lesson landed.

**Work every lesson in order. The Digital Revenue Journey builds on itself. Skipping Discovery to get to Closing faster is like skipping the foundation to get to the roof faster.**

### A realistic weekly rhythm

| Day   | What to do                                                                                                           |
|-------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Day 1 | Read the lesson once, fully, without stopping to do the drills yet.                                                  |
| Day 2 | Re-read the teaching and transcript sections slowly. Rewrite the transcript's key line in your own words.            |
| Day 3 | Run the role-play with a partner, in person, on a call, or against the AI role-play engine if you have access to it. |
| Day 4 | Do every drill. Time yourself where the drill asks for it.                                                           |
| Day 5 | Complete the self-check honestly. Anything you cannot answer, go back and re-read.                                   |

You will need a partner (another student, a friend, a mentor), a way to record yourself (your phone is enough), and a notebook or document for your growing script library. Nothing else.

## The job you are training for

Say "sales job" to most people and they picture someone standing outside a shop trying to convince a stranger to buy something they do not need. Delete that picture completely. It has nothing to do with what you are about to learn.

You are training to be a digital sales professional: the person who connects a piece of technology, software as a service, an AI product, a cybersecurity tool, a fintech

platform, to the business that actually needs it. Every technology company on earth, from a two-person Lagos automation studio to a global software giant, employs people to do exactly this job, because a brilliant product that nobody finds out about generates no revenue at all.

### Why this is a real career, not a side hustle

You do not need to learn to code to build a career in technology. There is another side of the technology industry, the side that finds customers, runs discovery, demonstrates products, solves business problems and closes deals. Every serious technology company needs people who can do that, and that need is not going away as AI changes how products get built; if anything, more products are getting built faster, which means more of them need someone to take them to market.

English fluency, a Nigerian time zone that overlaps comfortably with both Europe and the Americas for part of the day, and cultural warmth are genuine advantages you carry into this specific career. The obstacle is not ability. It is that most employers have never been shown proof a Nigerian candidate can do this job at a professional standard. This handbook, together with the Sales Lab and certification described in your programme, exists to hand you that proof.

| Track                 | What you do                               | Typical roles                                            |
|-----------------------|-------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| Setter / SDR          | Find, Start, Qualify, Discover            | SDR, BDR, Appointment Setter, Lead Generation Specialist |
| Closer / AE           | Present, Demonstrate, Handle, Close, Grow | Account Executive, Sales Closer, Inside Sales Executive  |
| Technology specialist | Deep focus on one category                | AI Sales, SaaS Sales, Cybersecurity Sales, Cloud Sales   |
| Sales operations      | Runs the pipeline and the numbers         | Sales Ops, Revenue Ops, CRM Specialist, Sales Analyst    |

**An honest note on money.** Your earning trajectory depends on your role, employer, market and experience. This handbook will not promise you a figure, because nobody honestly can this early. What is true: the closer your work sits to creating measurable business value, the more commercially valuable your skill becomes over time. Build the skill first.

# The professional mindset

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Four beliefs separate students who finish this handbook as employable professionals from students who finish it as people who read a book about selling.

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## 1. Evidence beats claims

"I completed a sales course" convinces nobody. A recorded discovery call, a closed Sales Lab simulation and a DSS Sales Readiness Score convince an employer who has never met you.

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## 2. Diagnosis before recommendation

A doctor who prescribes before examining is dangerous. A closer who pitches before discovering is expensive, for the buyer and for their own close rate.

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## 3. Honesty is a career strategy

Every ethical shortcut in this handbook is also, separately, a bad long-term career move. The two are not in tension. Trust compounds; so does the loss of it.

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## 4. AI is a tool you are accountable for

AI will draft your research, your follow-ups and your practice. You are still the one who is accountable for every word that reaches a real buyer under your name.

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## Part 1 · The digital economy & technology literacy

Lessons 1–5 · Foundation, before you ever contact a real prospect

# What digital sales actually is

## The demo nobody remembers

Tega had never sold anything in his life when a friend dragged him to watch a product demo at a Lagos coworking space. A young woman was showing a room of small business owners a new invoicing app. She spent twenty minutes clicking through every screen: the dashboard, the settings page, the notifications panel, the export function. When she finished, she asked if there were questions. Nobody had any. Nobody signed up either.

Three weeks later, Tega watched a different person demo a nearly identical product to a nearly identical room. This one opened differently: "Before I show you anything, tell me, how many hours a week does someone on your team spend chasing unpaid invoices?" A woman near the front said "probably six or seven, honestly." The presenter nodded. "Let me show you exactly what happens to those six or seven hours." Four people signed up before she had even finished the demo.

Same product. Same room, more or less. Completely different result. Tega spent the walk home trying to figure out what had actually changed, and slowly realised it wasn't confidence, or charisma, or even the product. It was that the second presenter had found out what the room actually needed before she ever opened her laptop.

## So what is digital sales, actually?

Forget every image you are carrying of a salesperson. Digital sales is the professional practice of connecting a piece of technology, software, an AI product, a cybersecurity tool, a fintech platform, to the specific business that needs it, and helping that business decide, with real evidence, that paying for it is worth it. Nobody is being tricked in that sentence. A real problem exists. A real solution exists. Your job is to bring the two together honestly and skilfully.

Notice the word "actually" doing quiet work in the demo story. The presenter who opened with a question was not being cleverer or more likeable. She was diagnosing before prescribing, the way a good doctor examines before writing a prescription. The first presenter, however polished, was prescribing blind: a full tour of every feature, offered to a room whose actual pain she had never

asked about. You are going to learn to be the second presenter, deliberately, as a repeatable skill rather than a lucky instinct.

### **The Digital Revenue Journey, your map for the whole handbook**

Every lesson in this handbook is training for one specific stage of a nine-stage journey: Find, Start, Qualify, Discover, Present, Demonstrate, Handle, Close, Grow. Memorise this order now, because it is the skeleton everything else hangs on. A Setter typically owns Find through Discover. A Closer typically owns Present through Grow. Both halves matter equally; a brilliant Closer fed a badly qualified opportunity will fail just as surely as a brilliant Setter whose qualified opportunities get fumbled at the demo.

### **Lead, prospect, opportunity, customer: four words you must stop using loosely**

A lead is a name with contact information, nothing confirmed yet. A prospect has responded and shown some real relevance. An opportunity has a confirmed problem, a confirmed budget-holder, and a realistic timeline, all three, not just enthusiasm. A customer has paid. Most beginners, and a surprising number of experienced salespeople, call things "opportunities" the moment a conversation feels good. Resist this completely. The whole value of a pipeline comes from these four words meaning something precise, every single time you use them.

#### **ANNOTATED: A FIRST QUALIFYING QUESTION, DONE WELL**

**BUYER:** "Yeah, we've been looking at automation tools, honestly not sure where to start."

Warm, but this is still a lead's sentence. Nothing confirmed yet, no real evidence of a problem or a budget.

**YOU:** "Totally get that, there's a lot out there. Can I ask, what's the actual task eating the most time right now, the one that made you start looking in the first place?"

One specific question, not five. Asking about the actual task, not the category "automation," starts to surface a real problem.

**BUYER:** "Honestly it's invoicing. Someone on my team spends most of a day every week just chasing payments."

Now you have something. A specific task, a specific cost (most of a day, every week). This is a prospect, not yet an opportunity, but it's real progress.

## Role-play 1.1 · The four-word sort

**Setup.** Your partner reads you five short, realistic scenarios (an inbound form fill, a LinkedIn reply, a warm referral, a trade show badge scan, a demo request). For each, say out loud, immediately, which of the four words applies, and the one piece of evidence that justifies it. No hedging.

### Drills

1. **The fifteen-name sort.** Take any list of fifteen real or invented technology-buyer contacts. Classify each as lead, prospect, opportunity or customer, with one line of evidence per contact.
2. **The demo replay.** Watch or read about any product demo you can find online. Note down, in one sentence, whether it opened with the buyer's problem or with the product's features.
3. **The nine-stage recite.** Say the full Digital Revenue Journey, all nine stages, out loud, three times in a row, from memory, without looking.

### Common mistakes

- Calling anyone who replies positively an "opportunity," regardless of whether budget or authority has actually been confirmed.
- Believing digital sales requires being naturally talkative or extroverted, rather than being naturally curious and disciplined.
- Opening every conversation with a description of your own company instead of a question about theirs.

### What world class looks like

A world-class digital sales professional can tell you, at any moment, exactly how many leads, prospects, opportunities and customers are in their pipeline, with evidence for every single one, and can explain in one sentence what would need to be true for any given lead to become a prospect.

### Self-check: Lesson 1

**1.** What is digital sales, in your own words?

*Answer:* Connecting a technology product to the business that needs it, and helping them decide honestly whether it's worth paying for.

**2.** What are the nine stages of the Digital Revenue Journey?

*Answer:* Find, Start, Qualify, Discover, Present, Demonstrate, Handle, Close, Grow.

**3.** What three things must be true before a prospect becomes an opportunity?

*Answer:* A confirmed problem, a confirmed budget-holder, a realistic timeline.

**4.** In the two-demo story, what was the actual difference between the two presenters?

*Answer:* The second one asked what the room needed before pitching; the first gave a full feature tour with no diagnosis first.

**5.** Why does calling every warm reply an "opportunity" cause real damage?

*Answer:* It makes your pipeline numbers dishonest, which misleads every decision built on top of them, including your own sense of how you're doing.

### LESSON 2

# The digital economy map

## The pitch that used the wrong word

Amara was three weeks into her first SDR role at a cybersecurity reseller when she got on a call with a fintech's operations lead. She opened confidently: "So we're basically like an app that helps you manage your software subscriptions." The buyer went quiet, then said, "I think you might have the wrong company, we're not really a SaaS business, we're a licensed payments platform." Amara had used "SaaS" as a catch-all word for anything digital, and it cost her the first ninety seconds of a call she never fully recovered.

## Seven categories, one vocabulary

You are going to spend your career selling into some mix of seven categories: SaaS, AI products, apps, cybersecurity, cloud, fintech, and automation or hardware. You do not need to master all seven equally. You do need to know, within thirty seconds of looking at a company, roughly which one you are dealing with, and you need to stop using "SaaS" the way Amara did, as a lazy synonym for "anything on a screen."

Underneath the category sits the business model, and this matters just as much. Subscription (pay monthly or yearly for ongoing access), usage-based (pay per unit consumed), one-time licence (pay once, own it), marketplace (a platform connecting two sides, taking a fee). A subscription sale is the start of an ongoing relationship you have to keep earning. A one-time sale is a single, larger decision made once. Selling these two the same way is a rookie mistake that shows within the first few sentences of any real conversation.

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### Role-play 2.1 · The thirty-second category guess

**Setup.** Your partner names a real technology company. You have thirty seconds to say its category, its likely business model, and whether it's B2B or B2C, out loud, before looking anything up. Then check together.

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## Drills

1. **The fifteen-company map.** Research and classify fifteen real technology companies across category, business model and B2B/B2C.
2. **The wrong-word audit.** Read back through anything you've written describing a technology product. Circle every place you used "SaaS," "app," or "platform" loosely, and correct it.

## Common mistakes

- Using "SaaS" as a generic word for any digital product, the exact mistake that cost Amara her opening.
- Assuming every technology company is B2B, when a large share of apps and fintech products sell directly to consumers.

### What world class looks like

A world-class digital sales professional can correctly categorise an unfamiliar technology company within thirty seconds of reading its homepage, and never uses "SaaS" to describe a product that isn't.

### Self-check: Lesson 2

1. Name the seven technology categories.

*Answer:* SaaS, AI products, apps, cybersecurity, cloud, fintech, automation and hardware.

2. What went wrong on Amara's call?

*Answer:* She called a licensed fintech payments platform "SaaS," a wrong and lazy category label that damaged her credibility immediately.

3. Why does a subscription sale require different behaviour than a one-time sale?

*Answer:* A subscription must be re-earned at every renewal; a one-time sale is a single larger decision made once.

## Technology literacy I: SaaS & AI

### The 99% that wasn't

A closer at an AI automation vendor told a bank, confidently, that their fraud-detection feature was "99% accurate." It sounded impressive on the call. It was also a number nobody at the company had actually measured for this specific use case; he had simply heard it somewhere and repeated it because it sounded like the kind of thing that closes deals. The bank's technical team tested the claim during a trial. Real-world accuracy came back closer to 80%. The deal did not die, but his credibility for the rest of the negotiation never fully recovered.

### You do not need to code. You need three questions.

Nobody expects you to build a SaaS product or train an AI model. What a technical buyer does expect is that you can ask an intelligent question and understand the answer, without pretending to know more than you do. Three questions work on almost any AI feature: what data does it use, what happens when it's wrong, and what has actually been measured about how accurate it is. Ask these of yourself before you say anything confident about a feature, and you will almost never end up in the closer's position above.

You also need three numbers every SaaS seller should be fluent in: MRR and ARR (monthly and annual recurring revenue, the predictable subscription income a company can count on), and churn (the rate customers cancel or fail to renew). A buyer's own finance team thinks in exactly these terms, and a seller who can't follow along sounds like an outsider fast.

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### Role-play 3.1 · Defend the number

**Setup.** Your partner plays a sceptical technical buyer who asks "how accurate is that, exactly?" about any AI feature you name. Answer only using information you could actually defend if pushed, never a number you're guessing at.

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## Drills

1. **Plain-English translation.** Take one real SaaS product's AI feature description from its own marketing page. Rewrite it in one paragraph a non-technical relative would understand.
2. **The three-question rehearsal.** Say the three safe AI questions aloud, from memory, five times in a row, until they come out naturally.

## Common mistakes

- Repeating an impressive-sounding statistic you heard somewhere without checking whether it's actually true for this product, this use case.
- Confusing MRR with total revenue, or churn with a one-off cancellation.

### What world class looks like

A world-class seller says "I don't know, let me confirm that and get back to you" more often than most beginners are comfortable with, and is trusted more, not less, because of it.

### Self-check: Lesson 3

1. What are the three safe questions to ask about any AI feature?

*Answer:* What data does it use, what happens when it's wrong, what has actually been measured about its accuracy.

2. What do MRR and ARR measure?

*Answer:* Monthly and annual recurring revenue, the predictable subscription income a business can count on.

3. What actually went wrong in the "99% accurate" story?

*Answer:* An unverified, unmeasured statistic was stated as fact and failed to hold up when the buyer's technical team tested it.

# Technology literacy II: cloud, cybersecurity, fintech & automation

## The question that wasn't about price

A cloud storage vendor's setter was mid-pitch to a Nigerian bank's IT director when she was interrupted: "Before you go further, is this on-premise or cloud, and what's your data residency policy?" She had no answer prepared. The call ended politely and went nowhere. Her manager later told her that question comes up on almost every serious bank conversation, and there is a standard, confident answer she simply hadn't been given yet.

## Four more categories, four different first questions

Cloud buyers ask about data residency, where is this actually stored, and does that comply with our regulator. Cybersecurity buyers ask for proof, not reassurance, certifications, audits, real case studies. Fintech buyers ask about licensing and regulatory compliance, a question you must never guess at. Automation buyers ask, often indirectly, "will this replace my staff," and the honest answer is usually that it frees people for higher-value work rather than eliminating their role.

Notice the pattern across all four: each category has its own predictable first serious question, and being ready for it, specifically, is worth more than a generic confident manner.

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### Role-play 4.1 · The four first questions

**Setup.** Your partner plays a buyer in one of the four categories and opens with that category's predictable first question, without telling you which category in advance. Answer it, then guess which category you were just tested on.

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## Drills

1. **Four briefs.** Pick one real product in each of the four categories. Write a one-paragraph plain-English explanation and the category's predictable first question for each.

## Common mistakes

- Treating all four categories as interchangeable "tech stuff" instead of learning each one's specific, predictable objection.

### What world class looks like

A world-class seller has their category's predictable first question answered before the buyer even asks it, folded naturally into the pitch.

### Self-check: Lesson 4

1. What does a cloud buyer typically ask about first?

*Answer:* Data residency, where the data is stored and whether that complies with their regulator.

2. What resolves a cybersecurity objection: reassurance or proof?

*Answer:* Proof, such as certifications, audits, or real case studies.

3. What is usually the honest answer to "will this replace my staff"?

*Answer:* It typically frees staff for higher-value work rather than eliminating the role entirely.

## LESSON 5

# Ethics & the DSS professional standard

## The integration that didn't exist

A software sales rep told a logistics company, with total confidence, "yes, it integrates with your existing system." He had not checked with engineering. It did not exist yet. Three weeks into a paid implementation, the client discovered this. They didn't just cancel the contract, worth roughly \$14m. They told two other companies in their industry association exactly why. One confident sentence, said to keep a call moving for thirty seconds, cost more than a year of one salesperson's salary.

## The manager test, and why it matters more in technology sales

Before stating any claim about integration, security, capability or timeline, ask yourself: would I be comfortable saying this exact sentence in front of my manager, with the buyer's own technical team in the room? If the honest internal version differs from what you're about to say, you already know the sentence fails, and you knew it before you said it.

Technology sales has three specific traps worth naming: overclaiming security posture ("fully secure," "unhackable," words no honest security professional would use), overstating AI capability (claiming intelligence or accuracy the product doesn't actually have), and promising an integration timeline nobody has confirmed with the people who'd actually have to build it. All three share the same shape: a confident sentence, said to keep momentum, checked with nobody who would actually know if it was true.

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### Role-play 5.1 · The manager test, live

**Setup.** Your partner asks you five realistic technical questions about a product you know. For each answer, say out loud whether it passes the manager test before you say it "for real."

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## Drills

1. **The ten-statement audit.** Write ten claims you might realistically make selling a technology product. Apply the manager test to each and rewrite any that fail.

## Common mistakes

- Treating an unconfirmed timeline as a small, harmless exaggeration rather than a claim you'd have to defend later.
- Rushing through signing your own professional charter as a formality rather than a real commitment.

## What world class looks like

A world-class professional says "let me confirm that and come back to you" without embarrassment, as often as needed, and is trusted more for it over a career, not less.

## Self-check: Lesson 5

1. What is the manager test?

*Answer:* Asking whether you'd be comfortable saying the exact same sentence in front of your manager, with the buyer's technical team present.

2. Name the three technology-sales ethical traps.

*Answer:* Overclaiming security, overstating AI capability, promising unconfirmed integration timelines.

3. What did the ₦14m logistics case actually cost, beyond the contract itself?

*Answer:* Two referral introductions the client had already been planning to make, lost along with the trust.

## Part 2 · Customer intelligence & AI-powered prospecting

Lessons 6–9 · Digital Revenue Journey: Find

### LESSON 6

## Customer intelligence: ICP, persona & decision-maker mapping

### The deal that died in a room nobody was in

An HR software rep closed what felt like a done deal. The IT manager loved it, ran the pilot enthusiastically, championed it internally for weeks. Then, at contract stage, silence. It turned out the company's Head of HR, who had never once joined a call, held real budget authority and had quietly decided the tool duplicated something already in procurement. She wasn't hostile. She simply had never been part of the conversation at all.

### Three roles, not one

Every real technology deal has a decision-maker (final sign-off authority), an influencer (shapes the decision without formal power), and often a blocker (can stop the deal without ever appearing to be involved). The IT manager in the story was a strong influencer. He was never the decision-maker, and the closer never found the real one until it was too late.

Your Ideal Customer Profile, built from your company's own best current customers, tells you which companies to target. Your buyer personas tell you which specific people inside those companies to reach, and how each one thinks. Skipping straight to "who replied first" instead of mapping all three roles is how good deals quietly die in rooms nobody thought to enter.

## Role-play 6.1 · Find the missing stakeholder

**Setup.** Your partner describes a deal scenario naming only one enthusiastic contact. Ask the three questions that would surface who else is actually involved, before you've been told anything about them.

### Drills

1. **The committee map.** For a real or assigned product, name a likely decision-maker, influencer and blocker, each with a one-sentence reason.

### Common mistakes

- Assuming the most enthusiastic, most responsive person in a deal is automatically the decision-maker.

### What world class looks like

A world-class Setter asks "besides yourself, who else would need to be comfortable with this" on nearly every qualifying call, early, before the enthusiasm of one contact creates false confidence.

### Self-check: Lesson 6

1. What is a blocker?

*Answer:* Someone who can stop a deal even without formal authority or visible involvement in the sales conversation.

2. What went wrong in the HR software story?

*Answer:* The real budget-holder, the Head of HR, was never engaged or even identified until the deal had already stalled.

# Why technology buyers actually buy

## The compliance deadline hiding behind "just exploring"

A logistics company told a software vendor they were "just exploring options" for a new inventory system. The vendor's rep took that at face value and pitched general efficiency gains for six slow weeks. Then, almost by accident, someone asked: "what happens if this isn't sorted by year end?" It turned out a new regulatory audit was coming, with a hard deadline nobody had mentioned. The real driver had never been efficiency. It was compliance, and once the pitch was rebuilt around it, the deal closed in two weeks.

## Status quo is the real competitor

Five drivers explain most B2B technology purchases: risk reduction, competitive pressure, compliance, cost reduction, and the fear of falling behind a competitor who has already adopted something similar. But the deepest lesson here is this: the strongest force in most technology deals isn't a rival vendor. It's simple inertia, the pull to keep doing things the current way. "We're comparing a few options" is very often status quo wearing a polite costume. Ask what happens if nothing changes for another year. If the honest answer reveals real hidden cost, you've found the real driver.

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### Role-play 7.1 · Past the first answer

**Setup.** Your partner gives a generic, believable reason for evaluating a technology purchase. Ask "what specifically changed to make this urgent now" and "what happens if nothing changes" until a more specific driver surfaces.

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### Drills

1. **Three real interviews.** Ask three people about a real technology decision they made or influenced. Trace the stated reason to the real driver using the questions above.

## Common mistakes

- Accepting a generic stated reason ("just exploring," "modernising") and pitching to it directly, without ever asking what changed.

### What world class looks like

A world-class Setter never lets a generic reason go unchallenged. They ask one more question, gently, every single time.

### Self-check: Lesson 7

**1.** Name the five common B2B technology buying drivers.

*Answer:* Risk reduction, competitive pressure, compliance, cost reduction, fear of falling behind a competitor.

**2.** What was the real driver in the logistics company story?

*Answer:* A new regulatory audit with a year-end deadline, a compliance driver hidden behind "just exploring."

## LESSON 8

# AI-powered prospecting

### The CEO who had already left

A junior setter used AI overnight to draft fifty personalised outreach messages, each naming the target company's CEO. Efficient, impressive, fast. Three of the fifty named a CEO who had left the company months earlier, a detail the AI tool hadn't caught and nobody had checked. All three replies were negative. One was shared publicly, screenshot and all, as an example of careless outreach.

### AI finds faster. You are still the one who checks.

AI genuinely changes what's possible here: researching a target account, identifying likely decision-makers, segmenting a list by fit, drafting personalised openers, all at a speed no human could match by hand. None of that changes one rule: no AI-drafted claim about a specific prospect reaches

that prospect until you have personally verified it against an independent source. The tool has no accountability. You do.

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### Role-play 8.1 · Catch the AI's mistake

**Setup.** Deliberately ask an AI tool for a detail about a real company likely to be outdated or wrong (a recent statistic, a named executive). Show your partner how you'd catch the error before it reached a real prospect.

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#### Drills

1. **Ten verified accounts.** Use AI to research ten target accounts. Verify one specific detail per account against a second, independent source before writing an opener.

#### Common mistakes

- Trusting a confident-sounding AI answer without a second, independent check, exactly the mistake in the CEO story.

#### What world class looks like

A world-class Setter uses AI constantly and still personally verifies every specific claim before it reaches a real prospect, without exception, every single time.

#### Self-check: Lesson 8

1. State the DSS AI accountability rule.

*Answer:* No AI-drafted claim about a specific prospect reaches them until a human has personally verified it.

2. What went wrong in the fifty-message story?

*Answer:* Three messages named a CEO who had already left the company, an outdated AI-sourced detail nobody verified.

## Building a multi-channel outbound sequence

### The email that went nowhere, twice

A cybersecurity startup's setter sent one well-crafted cold email to two hundred target accounts. Four replies came back. Discouraged, he wrote it off as a bad list. His manager suggested something different: the same two hundred accounts, but a full five-touch sequence across two channels instead of one lonely email. Reply rate rose to roughly twelve percent, from the exact same list.

### One message competes. A sequence gets chances.

A single cold message competes against everything else in an inbox at that one moment. A sequence, spaced two to four days apart across two to three weeks, gets multiple chances to land when the buyer is actually paying attention. Switch channel partway through, typically around touch three, because a prospect who has learned to filter out your emails may still notice a LinkedIn message, simply because it breaks the pattern.

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### Role-play 9.1 · Spot the repeat

**Setup.** Read your partner all five touches of a sequence you've written, out of order. They tell you if any two sound like the same ask reworded.

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### Drills

1. **Five touches, one account.** Write a complete five-touch, two-channel sequence for one real or invented target account.

### Common mistakes

- Writing five versions of the same ask, reworded, instead of five genuinely different touches.

### What world class looks like

A world-class sequence stops the moment a real reply arrives, and never fires a scheduled touch after genuine two-way conversation has already started.

### Self-check: Lesson 9

**1.** What is a realistic cadence for a B2B outbound sequence?

*Answer:* Touches spaced two to four days apart, across two to three weeks.

**2.** What fixed the cybersecurity startup's low reply rate?

*Answer:* Replacing a single email with a full five-touch, two-channel sequence, using the same list.

## Part 3 · Pipeline creation (Setter track)

Lessons 10–14 · Digital Revenue Journey: Start, Qualify

### LESSON 10

# The setter's job & pipeline KPIs

## The busier SDR who was actually behind

Two SDRs at the same SaaS company were given identical account lists. One sent three hundred messages and booked six meetings, two of which showed. The other sent one hundred and forty messages and booked eleven meetings, nine of which showed. Their manager, looking only at message volume, was about to praise the first one's "hustle" and quietly deprioritise the second.

## Rate before volume, always

Your job in one sentence: move the right opportunity from Find to a qualified handoff. Not "send messages." Nine numbers tell you exactly where your pipeline is leaking: response time, contact rate, engagement rate, qualification rate, appointment rate, show rate, follow-up completion, SLA compliance, qualified opportunities created. A setter who can diagnose the weakest one of these nine and fix that specifically, before adding more volume, is worth more than one who is simply busier. The story above is not rare. It is the single most common misjudgement in this entire job.

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### Role-play 10.1 · The ninety-second diagnosis

**Setup.** Your partner reads you six raw numbers (leads, contacted, replied, qualified, booked, showed). Calculate all relevant rates and name the weakest one, out loud, in under ninety seconds, timed.

---

#### Drills

1. **The KPI board.** Build a personal sheet with all nine metrics. Log real or practice numbers weekly, starting this week.

## Common mistakes

- Increasing outreach volume before diagnosing which specific rate is actually weak.

### What world class looks like

A world-class Setter can state their own current weakest rate, unprompted, at any point in a working week.

### Self-check: Lesson 10

1. State the setter's job in one sentence.

*Answer:* Move the right opportunity from Find to a qualified handoff.

2. Why must rate be fixed before volume is increased?

*Answer:* More outreach through a broken step produces more waste at that step, not more revenue.

## LESSON 11

# The first response & channel mastery for tech buyers

### The connection request that felt like spam

A junior SDR sent the identical LinkedIn connection message to every single prospect on her list, with zero reference to who any of them actually were. Acceptance rate sat under ten percent, and a handful of people reported the messages as spam outright. Her mentor's fix cost nothing: one line, referencing something true and specific from the prospect's own profile, before anything else.

### Fast means something different on every channel

Speed still wins, but "fast" is relative to the channel. A same-day LinkedIn reply is fast. A same-day WhatsApp reply is often already too slow. LinkedIn etiquette means no immediate pitch after connecting, a short first message, at most one gentle follow-up. Email etiquette for technical buyers means a subject line naming their likely problem, not your company name, and a short body they can scan in seconds. The one universal rule across every channel:

reference something specific and true about the recipient, or expect to be filtered out with everything else that didn't.

---

### Role-play 11.1 · Guess the channel

**Setup.** Write a first response to the same enquiry for three different channels. Your partner reads all three, unlabelled, and guesses which channel each was written for.

#### Drills

1. **The spam audit.** Review ten of your own real or practice outreach messages. Mark any that could read as spam to a technical buyer, and rewrite them.

### Common mistakes

- Using one identical template across every channel, exactly the mistake that hurt the SDR in the story.

#### What world class looks like

A world-class Setter's partner can always correctly guess which channel a message was written for, without being told.

#### Self-check: Lesson 11

1. Why does "fast" mean something different on LinkedIn than on WhatsApp?

*Answer:* Each channel has its own expected rhythm; a same-day LinkedIn reply is fast, a same-day WhatsApp reply is often already too slow.

2. What fixed the low LinkedIn acceptance rate in the story?

*Answer:* Adding one line referencing something specific and true from the prospect's own profile.

## Qualification for technology sales

### The proposal built on five minutes

A setter got a "we're interested, send something over" after a five-minute call. Excited, he spent three hours building a full customised proposal. The prospect went quiet the moment it arrived and never replied again. Nobody had confirmed budget, authority, or a real timeline. The excitement had felt like enough. It wasn't.

### Fit, Need, Authority, Timeline, in that order

Fit checks whether the prospect's situation genuinely matches what you sell, regardless of how enthusiastic they sound. Need is tested by asking what they use now and what's actually not working about it, far more reliable than "do you need this." Authority means naming who else has to approve. Timeline means confirming whether a real date, tied to a real event, actually drives the decision. If two or more of these come back weak, a graceful disqualification is the professional move, not a three-hour proposal built on hope.

---

### Role-play 12.1 · Full qualification, then a decision

**Setup.** Run the full Fit, Need, Authority, Timeline sequence with a partner playing a buyer. At the end, state out loud: proceed, or disqualify, with your reasoning.

---

### Drills

1. **The disqualification script.** Write a graceful, respectful disqualification for a prospect who fails two of the four criteria. Say it aloud to a partner.

### Common mistakes

- Treating enthusiasm as evidence of Need, exactly the trap in the three-hour-proposal story.

### What world class looks like

A world-class Setter can disqualify a friendly, enthusiastic prospect without either side feeling bad about the conversation afterward.

### Self-check: Lesson 12

1. What do Fit, Need, Authority and Timeline each confirm?

*Answer:* Fit: genuine match. Need: a real, costly problem. Authority: who can actually approve. Timeline: a real driving date.

2. What question tests Need more reliably than "do you need this"?

*Answer:* "What are you using now, and what's not working about it."

## LESSON 13

# Appointment setting & show-rate systems

### The show rate that more than doubled

A SaaS company's demo show rate sat stubbornly around a third. Sales engineering time was being wasted, repeatedly, on people who simply didn't turn up. Nothing about the demo itself changed. What changed was everything around the booking: a framing sentence, an immediate confirmation, a day-before reminder, a same-day nudge. Show rate climbed to close to four in five.

### Four messages, four different jobs

The framing paragraph states exactly what the demo will show and why it matters to this specific buyer's confirmed problem, before you ever ask for a time. Offer two named times, never an open "whenever works," because a choice is a smaller ask than a calendar search. Then four messages carry the booking home: the framing and ask together, an immediate confirmation with one prep question, a day-before reminder that restates the value, and a same-day nudge. Remove any one and show rate measurably drops.

### Role-play 13.1 · The full sequence, aloud

**Setup.** Deliver all four messages aloud to a partner, in order, for a demo booking tied to a specific discovered problem. They tell you if any message felt redundant.

#### Drills

1. **Run it for real.** The next time you book any real meeting, run all four messages, adapted to the actual situation, and track whether the person shows.

#### Common mistakes

- Offering an open "let me know what time works" instead of two specific named options.

#### What world class looks like

A world-class Setter's show rate sits consistently above the healthy range, not because of charm, but because of a disciplined four-message system run every single time.

#### Self-check: Lesson 13

1. Name the four messages in the show-up sequence.

*Answer:* Framing and ask, immediate confirmation, day-before reminder, same-day nudge.

2. Why two named times instead of an open question?

*Answer:* A choice between two options is a smaller ask than requiring the buyer to check their own calendar.

# The handoff to a closer

## The demo that opened with nothing

A setter had discovered a prospect's real, specific frustration: a failed CRM integration that had already wasted weeks. The handoff to the closer said only "interested in automation." The closer opened the demo with a generic feature tour. The buyer disengaged within two minutes, still waiting for anyone to mention the actual problem they'd spent twenty minutes describing to the setter.

## A handoff moves trust, not just a name

Your handoff must answer three questions for the closer: why is this buyer here, what have they already been told, and what specifically worries them. For a technology deal specifically, add a fourth: what is their current tooling and what exactly isn't working about it. A closer who opens by referencing that CRM integration failure directly proves, instantly, that this is a coordinated team, not a chain of strangers.

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### Role-play 14.1 · The blind open

**Setup.** Write a full handoff note. Hand it to a partner with zero other context and have them open a call using only what's written. Score it against the three-question test.

---

#### Drills

1. **Three real handoffs.** Write three complete handoff notes from real or practice conversations. Test each with a different partner.

#### Common mistakes

- Writing a handoff that lists surface facts but omits the specific technical frustration that actually matters.

### What world class looks like

A closer receiving a world-class handoff can open a call sounding like they've been part of the conversation from the start.

#### Self-check: Lesson 14

1. What three questions must a handoff answer?

*Answer:* Why the buyer is here, what they've already been told, what they're worried about.

2. What went wrong in the CRM integration story?

*Answer:* The specific technical frustration was never included in the handoff, so the closer opened generically and the buyer disengaged.

## Part 4 · Discovery, demo & value (Closer track)

Lessons 15–18 · Digital Revenue Journey: Discover, Present, Demonstrate

### LESSON 15

# Discovery for technology sales

## The eleven minutes that saved the deal

A closer asked a manufacturing client, "what's slow about your current process?" The answer: "it just takes too long." A less disciplined closer moves straight to a pitch here. This one stayed, asking specific follow-up after specific follow-up, for eleven more minutes, until the real bottleneck emerged: a fifteen-minute manual approval step, repeated dozens of times a day. The demo built around that one specific bottleneck closed within the week.

## Situation, Problem, Impact, Desired Outcome, Solution Fit

This is the heaviest-weighted skill in your entire certification, and for good reason. "It's slow" tells you nothing actionable. Stay in the Problem stage past the first answer, three questions deep at minimum, until it becomes something specific enough to build a real recommendation on. Then quantify Impact in the buyer's own words, "how much is that actually costing you." Then confirm Desired Outcome. Then, honestly, check Solution Fit, because a demo built on assumed fit disappoints everyone.

### ANNOTATED: STAYING IN THE PROBLEM STAGE

**CLOSER:** "Walk me through what happens today when an order comes in."

**BUYER:** "It's fine, honestly. Someone takes it down and passes it to the kitchen."

First answer, comfortable, not yet useful. Do not move on.

**CLOSER:** "Takes it down how, paper, phone?"

**BUYER:** "Paper, then she has to walk it over."

**CLOSER:** "And if she's busy with a table when it comes in?"

**BUYER:** "Then... I suppose it waits a bit."

Now something real is surfacing. Push one more time.

**CLOSER:** "How long is 'a bit' on your busiest night?"

**BUYER:** "Could be ten, fifteen minutes before the kitchen even sees it."

Five questions in, "it's fine" became a specific, measurable delay on the most profitable night of the week.

## Role-play 15.1 · Five questions deep

**Setup.** Ask your partner about any area of their work. Commit, before starting, to at least five follow-up questions inside that one area before moving on, no matter how complete the first answer sounds.

### Drills

1. **Two full discoveries.** Run two complete five-stage discovery calls with different partners, staying three questions deep in Problem each time.

### Common mistakes

- Accepting the first, vague answer and moving straight to a pitch.
- Skipping Solution Fit and simply assuming the product fits.

### What world class looks like

A world-class Closer's discovery transcript reads like a specific, quantified problem, never a general complaint.

### Self-check: Lesson 15

1. Name the five discovery stages.

*Answer:* Situation, Problem, Impact, Desired Outcome, Solution Fit.

2. What did the eleven extra minutes uncover in the manufacturing story?

*Answer:* A specific fifteen-minute manual approval bottleneck happening dozens of times a day.

# Product demonstration: demo the outcome, not the feature

## The forty-minute tour nobody needed

A sales engineer ran his standard forty-minute feature tour for a prospect whose discovery had surfaced exactly one narrow, specific problem. The buyer, having already seen what mattered to them in the first ten minutes, sat through thirty more minutes of unrelated content and quietly checked out. He never came back for a second call.

## Open with the outcome, show three features, close with a next step

A demo is not a tour. It is proof that your discovery was real. Open within ninety seconds by restating the buyer's specific problem and showing exactly how the product addresses it, not a homepage walkthrough. Show three features maximum, each tied directly to something discovery surfaced. Resist every "while we're here" detour; every unrelated feature dilutes the ones that matter and risks a new objection nobody asked for. Close with a specific next step, never an open "any questions?"

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### Role-play 16.1 · Ninety seconds, timed

**Setup.** Using a real discovery transcript, open a demo live, timed by your partner, aiming to reference the buyer's specific problem within ninety seconds.

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#### Drills

1. **Three tied features.** Pick a product. Choose exactly three features tied to a specific discovered problem, and drop everything else, no matter how impressive.

#### Common mistakes

- Opening with a general product tour before ever reaching the buyer's actual problem.

### What world class looks like

A world-class demo could be interrupted after ninety seconds and the buyer would already know exactly why it matters to them.

### Self-check: Lesson 16

1. What should a demo open with?

*Answer:* The buyer's specific discovered problem, not a general product tour.

2. How many features should a demo show, maximum?

*Answer:* Three, each tied to the buyer's discovered problem.

## LESSON 17

# Value selling: feature to financial impact

### The feature nobody could explain

A cybersecurity company's team kept describing their key feature as "automated threat scoring," full stop. Technically accurate, commercially meaningless. Buyers heard a description and moved on. Once someone climbed the ladder all the way, automated threat scoring, which means the security team stops manually triaging hundreds of alerts, which means the two best analysts spend their time on real threats instead of noise, which means fewer missed incidents, the feature suddenly became a stated reason buyers chose to purchase.

### Feature, Capability, Business Value, Financial Impact

Climb all four rungs, every time. Feature is what it is. Capability is what it lets someone do. Business Value is what changes for the company. Financial Impact is what that's actually worth. Stopping at Capability, "it automatically scores threats," is still just describing the product. Land the top rung on something the specific buyer already told you they care about; a generic

"which means more revenue" does far less work than one tied to their own stated pain.

---

### Role-play 17.1 · Climb it live

**Setup.** Your partner names any technology feature. Climb the full four-rung ladder out loud, without stopping at Capability.

#### Drills

1. **Five features, five ladders.** Build full four-rung ladders for five real features, at least three from the same product.

### Common mistakes

- Stopping at Capability and calling it Business Value.

#### What world class looks like

A world-class Closer never describes a feature without also stating, unprompted, what it's actually worth.

#### Self-check: Lesson 17

1. Name the four rungs of the value ladder.

*Answer:* Feature, Capability, Business Value, Financial Impact.

2. What was the cybersecurity company's mistake?

*Answer:* Stopping at Capability, describing what the feature does technically without ever climbing to its actual value.

# Presenting & pricing a technology solution

## The discount offered into silence

A closer stated an annual price. Two seconds of silence followed. Uncomfortable, he offered fifteen percent off before the buyer had said a single word. The buyer, who had actually been quietly calculating whether the original number worked, paused instead to wonder whether pushing further might unlock an even bigger discount.

## Restate, recommend, price, then say nothing

Good discovery makes this short: restate the problem in the buyer's own words, present the recommendation tied directly to it, explain whether pricing is tiered, seat-based or usage-based and why that fits them, state the price, and then hold real silence, a minimum of five seconds, while the buyer genuinely processes the number. That silence is almost always your discomfort, not theirs. Let them speak first.

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### Role-play 18.1 · Fifteen seconds

**Setup.** State a price to your partner and hold silence for fifteen full seconds, timed by a third person. Most people break well before fifteen on the first try.

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### Drills

1. **Full presentation, timed.** Deliver the full restate-recommend-price-silence sequence for a real discovery scenario.

### Common mistakes

- Filling silence with justification or an unprompted discount before the buyer has said anything.

### What world class looks like

A world-class Closer states a price and then says nothing else until the buyer speaks, every single time, no matter how long it takes.

#### Self-check: Lesson 18

1. Whose discomfort is the silence after a price usually reflecting?

*Answer:* The seller's, not the buyer's, who is generally using the time to genuinely think.

2. What went wrong in the discount story?

*Answer:* An unprompted discount was offered into silence before the buyer had said anything, undermining the original price.

## Part 5 · Objections, closing & negotiation

Lessons 19–21 · Digital Revenue Journey: Handle, Close

### LESSON 19

# Objection handling for technology buyers

## The internal tool nobody should have criticised

A closer heard "we already built something like this internally" and responded by listing everything the internal tool lacked. The prospect, who had personally built it, went visibly defensive. The deal stalled for weeks. On a near-identical deal later, a different closer asked instead: "what's it been like keeping that maintained and updated?" The prospect arrived at the real cost themselves, without ever feeling criticised.

## Diagnose the root before you respond to the words

Four objections come up constantly in technology sales: "we built this internally," "how do we know our data is safe," "we're locked into a competitor," and "who else uses this at our scale." Acknowledge first, always. Then clarify what's really underneath it before responding. Build versus buy usually isn't about the tool's quality, it's about pride and unconsidered maintenance cost. Security objections need proof, a certification, an audit, never reassurance alone.

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### Role-play 19.1 • All four, in sequence

**Setup.** Your partner raises each of the four objections in turn. Run the acknowledge-clarify-respond sequence for each before moving to the next.

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### Drills

1. **Six-objection library.** Write full responses for the four covered here plus two more realistic ones you invent.

### Common mistakes

- Criticising a prospect's internal tool directly, the exact mistake that stalled the first deal in the story.

### What world class looks like

A world-class Closer's response to "we built this internally" is a question, not an argument.

### Self-check: Lesson 19

1. What's the wrong first response to a build-versus-buy objection?

*Answer:* Arguing the internal tool is inferior, which puts you at odds with the prospect's own work.

2. What resolves a data-security objection?

*Answer:* Specific proof, a certification or audit reference, not general reassurance.

## LESSON 20

# Closing technology deals

### "Let's move forward" wasn't the finish line

A first-time closer heard "this looks great, let's move forward" and mentally closed the deal on the spot. Three months later it still hadn't signed. Procurement, security review, budget approval, three separate people he'd never spoken to, each needed to sign off before anything became real.

### A buying signal, and what happens after it

Enthusiasm is a feeling. A buying signal is specific and actionable: a request for contract terms, a security review, an introduction to procurement. Once you get a real signal, expect a formal process, possibly involving people you've never met. A proof of concept, if offered, needs a hard time box and explicit, written success criteria agreed before it starts, or it can run for months with no decision ever reached.

## Role-play 20.1 · Structure the trial

**Setup.** Your partner asks for "just a quick trial" with no structure. Propose a time-boxed proof of concept with specific, written success criteria before agreeing to anything.

### Drills

1. **The proof-of-concept proposal.** Write a structured proposal with a start date, end date, and three specific success criteria for a simulated deal.

### Common mistakes

- Treating "let's move forward" as a closed deal instead of the start of procurement.

### What world class looks like

A world-class Closer never lets a pilot begin without a written end date and agreed success criteria already in place.

### Self-check: Lesson 20

1. What distinguishes a buying signal from enthusiasm?

*Answer:* A buying signal is specific and actionable; enthusiasm has no specific next action attached.

2. What must a proof of concept have to be properly structured?

*Answer:* A time box and explicit, pre-agreed success criteria.

# Negotiation

## The tranches that closed a stuck \$4.2m deal

A buyer kept saying a \$4.2m annual price "wasn't something I can get approved right now," without ever naming a lower number. A closer, instead of reaching for a discount, asked directly: "is that the total, or how it lands in one go?" It turned out the quarterly budget couldn't absorb the full amount at once, though the annual budget could handle it across the year. Restructured into quarterly instalments, the full price closed within three days.

## Trade, don't discount. Diagnose before either.

Open with a genuine, defensible price, one you actually believe in, not an inflated number designed to be talked down. When a discount request arrives with no stated reason, ask directly whether it's a fixed budget, a timing issue, or unconvinced value, before offering anything. Then trade, a longer term, a reference commitment, a faster decision, rather than simply giving money away for nothing in return. Decide your walk-away point before the negotiation starts, in writing, where you'll actually see it.

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### Role-play 21.1 • Diagnose the hidden constraint

**Setup.** Your partner asks for an unexplained discount, with a real constraint decided privately that you don't know. Ask the diagnostic question before offering anything.

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#### Drills

1. **The trade menu.** Write five concrete, specific trades you could offer instead of a straight discount.

### Common mistakes

- Offering a discount before ever asking what the request is actually standing in for.

### What world class looks like

A world-class negotiator asks one diagnostic question before ever touching the price, every time, without exception.

#### Self-check: Lesson 21

**1.** What question diagnoses the real constraint behind a discount request?

*Answer:* Whether it's against a fixed budget or whether the price feels like more than the value justifies.

**2.** What was the real obstacle in the ¥4.2m tranche story?

*Answer:* How the payment landed in one go against a quarterly budget, not the annual total itself.

## Part 6 · Revenue & AI operations

Lessons 22–25 · Digital Revenue Journey: Grow, and the whole pipeline

### LESSON 22

# CRM & pipeline management for technology sales

## The \$60m that was mostly hope

A SaaS startup believed it had \$60m in active pipeline. A proper audit, checking every record's stage against real evidence, found less than a third of that was genuinely qualified. The founder had been about to plan a hiring round around a number that was mostly optimism wearing a CRM label.

## A stage is a fact, not a feeling

Nine stages: Lead, Contacted, Engaged, Qualified, Meeting, Opportunity, Proposal, Negotiation, Won or Lost. Two failure modes corrupt this silently: stage skipping (moving forward without satisfying the stage in between) and stage hoarding (leaving a record parked long after it's clearly changed, checked by the last-activity date, not the label). Every stage change deserves one line of real evidence, written at the time, not reconstructed from memory later.

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### Role-play 22.1 · Defend the stage

**Setup.** Your partner names a pipeline stage for a record. You must state the specific evidence that justifies it, or admit it should be downgraded.

#### Drills

1. **The fifteen-record audit.** Audit fifteen real or simulated pipeline records for stage-skipping and stage-hoarding errors.

## Common mistakes

- Treating stage hoarding as harmless, when it corrupts a pipeline just as much as skipping, in the opposite direction.

### What world class looks like

A world-class Closer's pipeline could be handed to a stranger, and every stage would still make honest sense.

### Self-check: Lesson 22

1. Name the nine CRM pipeline stages.

*Answer:* Lead, Contacted, Engaged, Qualified, Meeting, Opportunity, Proposal, Negotiation, Won or Lost.

2. What evidence exposes stage hoarding that content alone might not?

*Answer:* The last-activity date on the record.

## LESSON 23

# Sales analytics & forecasting

### The cheaper fix that produced the same result

A team's pipeline showed two weak numbers: qualification at 30% and demo-to-close at 20%. Instinct said fix closing, "it's closer to the money." The actual arithmetic showed both fixes would produce nearly identical additional revenue, but the qualification fix was a cheap scripting change, while the closing fix meant weeks of expensive coaching. The math, not the instinct, picked the winner.

### Calculate before you prioritise

Read your conversion rate at every stage of the Digital Revenue Journey against the healthy range. When two rates are both weak, don't guess which to fix first, calculate: "if this moved from X to Y, holding everything else constant, that produces approximately Z in additional revenue." Then weigh the calculated gain against the real cost of the fix. Cheaper and equally effective beats expensive and equally effective, every time.

### Role-play 23.1 · Two fixes, one winner

**Setup.** Your partner gives you two candidate fixes with numbers attached. Calculate the revenue impact of both out loud and recommend one, with the arithmetic shown.

#### Drills

1. **Full diagnosis.** Given a full set of pipeline numbers, calculate every conversion rate and complete the revenue-impact comparison for the two weakest.

#### Common mistakes

- Prioritising the rate that "feels closer to the money" without calculating actual impact.

#### What world class looks like

A world-class sales analyst can produce the revenue-impact number for any proposed fix within a couple of minutes, on demand.

#### Self-check: Lesson 23

1. What must be held constant when calculating one fix's revenue impact?

*Answer:* All other rates in the pipeline.

2. Why was the qualification fix chosen over the closing fix in the story?

*Answer:* Both produced nearly identical revenue, but the qualification fix was far cheaper and faster to implement.

# AI sales operations

## The summary that missed the real concern

A closer used AI to summarise a discovery call and sent a follow-up based on that summary alone, without re-reading the transcript. The summary had quietly compressed away a specific data-residency concern the buyer had raised in passing. The follow-up never addressed it. The buyer felt unheard, and rightly so.

## Four points, one rule that never bends

AI helps before the call (research), during preparation (likely questions and objections), after the call (summarising), and in follow-up (drafting messages). Use it at all four, constantly. The rule that never bends: no AI-drafted claim, summary or message reaches a real buyer, or gets acted on, until you've personally checked it against the source. Checking ten AI outputs costs minutes. One uncorrected error reaching a real buyer can cost the whole relationship.

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### Role-play 24.1 · Summary versus transcript

**Setup.** Have an AI tool summarise a transcript containing one small but important detail. Check whether the summary preserved it. Report what you found to your partner.

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### Drills

1. **Four-point workflow.** Use AI at all four points for one simulated deal, documenting one specific correction needed at each point.

### Common mistakes

- Acting on an AI summary without comparing it against the full source transcript.

### What world class looks like

A world-class user of AI in sales checks every output, every time, without exception, and can name specifically what they checked.

### Self-check: Lesson 24

1. State the DSS AI accountability rule.

*Answer:* No AI-drafted claim, summary or message reaches a real buyer, or gets acted on, until a human has verified it.

2. What did the AI summary miss in the story?

*Answer:* A specific data-residency concern the buyer raised in passing, which the follow-up then never addressed.

## LESSON 25

# Revenue leak recovery

### Four months of pipeline everyone assumed was dead

A sales team stopped working their older records, assuming they were simply dead. An audit found real, uncontacted and stalled opportunities sitting untouched, the two leak types with the highest realistic recovery rate. Working just those two first, for ten days, recovered real revenue from a list that had cost nothing extra to work; it had already been paid for once.

### Five leaks, sequenced by how recoverable they actually are

Uncontacted leads, stalled conversations, qualified opportunities never booked, meetings held with no logged outcome, and dormant accounts closed without a proper exit. Not all five recover equally. Uncontacted and stalled recover fastest, dormant recovers slowest. Work in that order. When you present a recovery report, state your recovery-rate assumptions plainly; an honest, defensible number builds more trust than an impressive, oversold one.

## Role-play 25.1 · Present it straight

**Setup.** Present a recovery report to a partner playing a sceptical owner, in an honest, non-oversold tone. Time yourself; aim for under four minutes before they start asking questions.

### Drills

1. **Full audit.** Classify a pipeline of at least fifty records into the five leak types, assign recovery-rate assumptions, and write the report.

### Common mistakes

- Treating all five leak types as equally urgent instead of sequencing by real recoverability.

### What world class looks like

A world-class recovery report is boring, specific, and exactly as confident as the evidence actually supports, no more.

### Self-check: Lesson 25

1. Name the five technology-pipeline leaks.

*Answer:* Uncontacted leads, stalled conversations, qualified never booked, meetings with no logged outcome, dormant accounts closed without a proper exit.

2. Which leak type generally has the highest realistic recovery rate?

*Answer:* Uncontacted leads, because interest is often still fresh.

## Part 7 · The Sales Lab & getting deployed

Lessons 26–28 · The full Digital Revenue Journey, then the real job search

### LESSON 26

## The DSS Sales Lab: full simulation

### The closest thing to a real job you'll have before you have one

Every skill in this handbook so far has been practised in isolation: one discovery call, one objection, one demo. A real job never works that way. It demands all of it, in the same week, sometimes the same day. The Sales Lab is where you find out, honestly, whether you can actually do this, not just discuss it.

### One company, one full journey, real evidence at every stage

You'll be given a fictional technology company brief, for example CloudFlow, an AI-powered workflow automation platform, targeting companies of 50 to 500 employees, priced at ₦2,000,000 annually. Your assignment: 20 qualified opportunities, 5 booked meetings, 2 discovery calls, 1 demonstration, 5 objections handled, 1 simulated closed deal. Every number maps to a skill you've already built. This is integration, not new content, and it produces the first real entries in your certification file.

### Drills

1. **Run the full Sales Lab.** Complete the entire assignment against your assigned brief, producing a real artifact, a list, a transcript, a recording, at every stage.
2. **Honest self-review.** Write half a page: what went well, your weakest stage, and one specific change for next time.

## Common mistakes

- Rushing later stages to hit the numeric targets, sacrificing genuine quality for a completed checklist.

### What world class looks like

A world-class Sales Lab run produces evidence a real employer could review and believe, at every single stage.

### Self-check: Lesson 26

**1.** Name the six numeric targets in the Sales Lab assignment.

*Answer:* 20 qualified opportunities, 5 booked meetings, 2 discovery calls, 1 demonstration, 5 objections handled, 1 simulated closed deal.

**2.** Why does the Sales Lab matter beyond practice?

*Answer:* It produces real, evidenced artifacts that form the first entries in your DSS certification file.

## LESSON 27

# Building your portfolio & DSS certification

### "Here, judge for yourself"

Two candidates apply for the same SDR role. One says, "I completed a twelve-week digital sales course." The other hands over eleven real pieces of work: a prospecting list, a recorded discovery call, a closed Sales Lab simulation, a CRM pipeline export. The interview changes completely. It's no longer "convince me." It's "show me," and the second candidate already has.

### Eleven pieces, mostly already sitting in your own work

ICP analysis, prospecting list, outbound campaign, email sequence, LinkedIn campaign, discovery recording, product demo recording, objection-handling recording, sales proposal, CRM pipeline export, case study write-up. Almost everything you need already exists somewhere in Lessons 1 through 26. This

stage is assembly and honest quality review, not creating from nothing. Find the gaps. Fill them properly before you present anything.

### Drills

1. **Map and fill.** Map your existing work against all eleven pieces. List every gap. Fill each one.
2. **Outside eyes.** Show your assembled portfolio to someone outside your cohort. Write down their honest, unprompted reaction.

### Common mistakes

- Leaving a weak piece in the portfolio instead of taking the time to strengthen it.

### What world class looks like

A world-class portfolio makes an interviewer stop asking "can you do this" and start asking "tell me more about this specific piece."

### Self-check: Lesson 27

1. Name four of the eleven portfolio pieces.

*Answer:* Any four of: ICP analysis, prospecting list, outbound campaign, email sequence, LinkedIn campaign, discovery recording, demo recording, objection-handling recording, sales proposal, CRM export, case study.

2. Where does most portfolio content actually come from?

*Answer:* Work already produced across earlier lessons, assembled and reviewed, not created fresh.

# Career tracks & getting deployed

## The CV that got shortlisted before the interview

A hiring manager was drowning in near-identical CVs, all listing course completions with no way to tell candidates apart. One DSS graduate's CV led differently: a stated Readiness Score, and a direct link to a recorded discovery call and a closed Sales Lab simulation. The hiring manager reviewed real evidence before the first interview even happened. That candidate was shortlisted from the CV alone.

## Choose your track from evidence, then lead with it

Pick your specialisation, Setter, Closer, technology specialist, business development, operations, or entrepreneurship, based on where your Sales Lab and Readiness Index actually showed strength, not just preference. Build a CV that leads with your Readiness Score and links straight to portfolio evidence, not a course-completion summary. Work several real application routes at once: direct applications, internships, freelance and agency work, warm introductions. Remember the actual DSS promise: not a job, but genuine, evidenced preparation to compete for one.

### Drills

1. **Build the package.** Choose your track with a stated reason. Draft a portfolio-first CV and update LinkedIn to match.
2. **Ninety seconds.** Practise a ninety-second self-introduction naming your track, your Readiness Score, and one specific portfolio piece. Deliver it to someone outside your cohort and ask what they remember five minutes later.

## Common mistakes

- Choosing a track because it sounds impressive rather than because your own evidence actually supports it.

### What world class looks like

A world-class graduate's CV gets read differently within the first ten seconds, because it leads with evidence, not a claim.

### Self-check: Lesson 28

1. What should determine your track choice, primarily?

*Answer:* Demonstrated strength from your Sales Lab and Readiness Index evidence, not preference alone.

2. What does DSS actually promise a graduate?

*Answer:* Not a job, but genuine preparation to compete for one, with evidence.

## Script & objection library

Every script from this handbook's role-plays, collected in one place for quick reference.

| Situation                     | What to say                                                                                                                 |
|-------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Opening a discovery question  | "Can I ask, what's the actual task eating the most time right now, the one that made you start looking in the first place?" |
| Testing a stated reason       | "What specifically changed to make this urgent now?" then "What happens if nothing changes?"                                |
| Testing Need in qualification | "What are you using now, and what's not working about it?"                                                                  |
| Mapping the buying committee  | "Besides yourself, who else would need to be comfortable with this before it moves forward?"                                |
| Demo framing, before booking  |                                                                                                                             |

|                                    |                                                                                                                                                                 |
|------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                                    | "I'd love to show you exactly how this handles [the specific problem], not a generic walkthrough. I've got Wednesday 11am or Thursday 3pm, which works better?" |
| "We already built this internally" | "That makes sense. What's it been like keeping that maintained and updated as things change?"                                                                   |
| "How do we know our data is safe"  | Offer a specific certification, audit reference or technical document, never reassurance alone.                                                                 |
| Unexplained discount request       | "Is that against a fixed budget, or does it feel like more than the value justifies right now?"                                                                 |
| Stalled payment amount             | "Is it the total, or how it lands in one go?"                                                                                                                   |
| Closing after a confirmed yes      | "Great, I'll get the paperwork moving today, is this email still the best one for the contract?"                                                                |

## Glossary

| Term             | Simple meaning                                                                                        |
|------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| ICP              | Ideal Customer Profile: the specific kind of company most likely to buy and succeed with the product. |
| SaaS             | Software as a Service: software rented on subscription rather than bought once.                       |
| MRR / ARR        | Monthly / Annual Recurring Revenue, the predictable subscription income a company can count on.       |
| Churn            | The rate paying customers cancel or fail to renew.                                                    |
| POC / pilot      | Proof of concept: a small, time-boxed trial before a full contract commitment.                        |
| Buying committee | The group of people who together decide on a technology purchase.                                     |
| Procurement      | The formal internal process that reviews and approves a purchase.                                     |

|                           |                                                                                                 |
|---------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| API / integration         | A defined way two systems exchange data; enough understanding needed to discuss it credibly.    |
| Champion                  | The internal advocate who wants the deal to happen and helps sell it to others internally.      |
| Blocker                   | Someone who can stop a deal even without formal authority.                                      |
| DSS Sales Readiness Index | The ten-competency scorecard DSS uses to assess and certify students.                           |
| Digital Revenue Journey   | The nine-stage path: Find, Start, Qualify, Discover, Present, Demonstrate, Handle, Close, Grow. |

## Self-assessment tracker

Score yourself 1 to 5 on each competency at Week 4, Week 8 and Week 12. Be honest; this tracker is for you, not for anyone else.

| Competency            | Week 4 | Week 8 | Week 12 |
|-----------------------|--------|--------|---------|
| Technology literacy   |        |        |         |
| Prospecting           |        |        |         |
| Communication         |        |        |         |
| Qualification         |        |        |         |
| Discovery             |        |        |         |
| Product demonstration |        |        |         |
| Value selling         |        |        |         |
| Objection handling    |        |        |         |
| Closing               |        |        |         |
|                       |        |        |         |

**Work it, do not read it. Record yourself. Find a partner. Keep your numbers.**

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